He said the Soviet opposition was based on a conviction that such weapons could be used both for defensive and offensive purposes.

“You have said, Mr. President, that the U.S. has no intention of using the SDI program for achieving military superiority,” Gorbachev wrote.

> I am sure that you personally could not have any such intention. But, we agree that it is the duty of the leaders of both sides to evaluate the actions of the other in the area of the creation of new types of weapons not in terms of intentions, but rather in terms of the potential capability which might be achieved due to the creation of a new weapon. Viewing the SDI program from such a position the Soviet leadership inevitably arrives at one conclusion: in the current actual conditions, the “space shield” is needed only by the side which is preparing for a first (preemptive) strike. For the side which does not proceed from this notion, the need for such a weapon does not arise. Indeed, space-strike weapons are all global weapons. The space-strike weapons being developed in the U.S. are kinetic energy and long range directed energy systems with a range of several thousand miles and are capable of great destructive power. As both our experts and scientists confirm, these weapons are capable of destroying in space as well as from space within a very short time in great quantities and selectively objects which are thousands of miles away and I stress, thousands of miles away, and [with] a capability to destroy the other side’s monitoring, navigation, communication and other space systems by striking from guided space weapons.

Gorbachev’s letter continued: